

RH10

Architecture: Forts, Palaces, Temples, Havelis, Stepwells

About 2-3 questions a paper. In 2023 alone two questions came out of fort typology. Expect at least one match-the-following and one NOT-correctly-matched.

This is the biggest pure-matching chapter in Rajasthan Art and Culture. Fort to type, fort to builder, fort to district, temple to place, stepwell to town — RPSC asks it as List-I / List-II almost every year. You are not learning architecture here. You are learning pairs.

Architecture of Rajasthan

Fort types

- Giri - Chittorgarh
- Jal - Gagron
- Dhanva - Jaisalmer
- Van - forest belt
- Eran - Chambal ravines
- Parikh - Lohagarh
- Sahay / Sainya

UNESCO Hill Forts 2013

- Chittorgarh
- Kumbhalgarh
- Ranthambore
- Amber
- Jaisalmer
- Gagron

Other UNESCO sites

- Keoladeo 1985
- Jantar Mantar 2010
- Walled City Jaipur 2019

Palaces

- Hawa Mahal - Pratap Singh
- Umaid Bhawan - Umaid Singh
- Lalgarh - Ganga Singh
- Jal Mahal - Man Sagar lake

Temples

- Dilwara - Mount Abu
- Ranakpur - Pali
- Osian - Jodhpur
- Kiradu - Barmer
- Jagat - Udaipur
- Rajorgarh - Alwar

Water & memory

- Chand Baori Abhaneri
- Raniji ki Baori Bundi
- Toorji ka Jhalra
- Panna Meena Amber
- Gaitor chhatris
- Jaswant Thada

Havelis

- Patwon ki Haveli
- Nathmal ki Haveli
- Salim Singh ki Haveli
- Shekhawati painted havelis

Start with typology — this is where the marks are

The old texts on statecraft, the Shukraniti and Manu, classify a fort by what protects it. Not by who built it. Not by how big it is. By the natural defence around it. RPSC lifts this classification straight out of the textbook and asks you to match a fort to its type. Learn the eight names first, then hang one Rajasthan example on each.

Fort typology and the standard Rajasthan example

Type	What protects it	Standard example
Giri durg	A hill	Chittorgarh, Kumbhalgarh, Ranthambore
Jal / audak durg	Water on the flanks	Gagron (Jhalawar)
Dhanva / marusthaliya durg	Desert	Jaisalmer
Van / aranya durg	Forest and thorn scrub	Forest forts of the Aravalli belt
Eran durg	Ravines and broken land	Chambal ravine country, Bhainsrorgarh side
Parikh durg	A dug moat	Lohagarh (Bharatpur), Junagarh (Bikaner)
Sahay durg	Loyal allies around it	-
Sainya durg	A standing army	-

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 — Gagron Fort of Jhalawar is classified as which type of fort? Answer: jal durg. It stands where the Kali Sindh meets the Ahu, so water guards it on three sides. Two more Gagron one-liners: it was built by Bijaldev Dod, it is said to rest on rock with no laid foundation, and it saw two sakas, in 1423 and 1444. The dargah of the Sufi saint Mitthe Shah lies just below the fort.

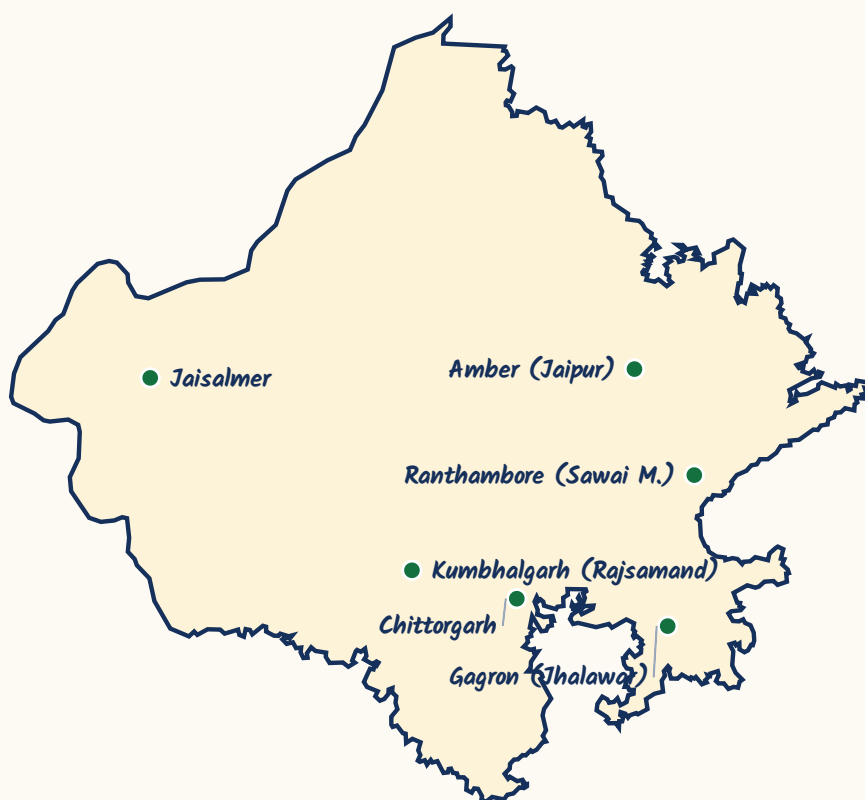
TRAP

Do not write Ranthambore as a jal durg. RAS Pre 2023 asked the NOT-correctly-matched version and Ranthambore was the wrong pair — it sits on an isolated hill where the Aravalli meets the Vindhyas, so it is a giri durg. Also keep the water pair straight: jal means a river on the flanks (Gagron), parikh means a dug moat (Lohagarh).

The six UNESCO Hill Forts, and Rajasthan's four World Heritage properties

In 2013, at the 37th session of the World Heritage Committee, UNESCO inscribed six Rajasthan forts as a single serial property called the Hill Forts of Rajasthan. Serial property means one listing, six components. Learn all six by name and district. Coaching lists keep adding a seventh fort to confuse you — there are exactly six.

The six UNESCO Hill Forts of Rajasthan (2013)

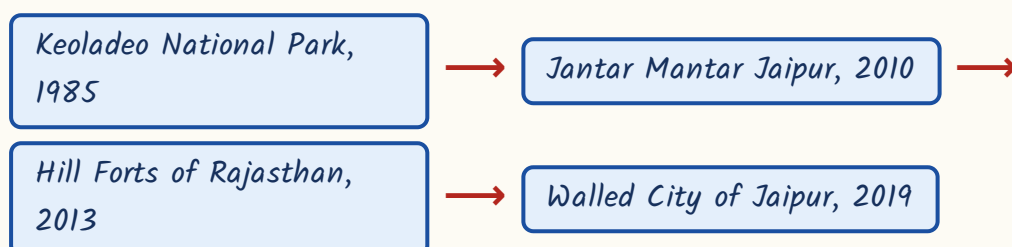


Five are giri durg; Gagron alone is a jal durg. Bhainsrorgarh is NOT in the list.

The six Hill Forts of Rajasthan (UNESCO 2013)

Fort	District	Key builder / founder
Chittorgarh	Chittorgarh	Mori ruler Chitrangada (founder)
Kumbhalgarh	Rajsamand	Rana Kumbha, 1443-58
Ranthambore	Sawai Madhopur	Chauhan-period hill fort
Amber	Jaipur	Raja Man Singh I, present form from 1592
Jaisalmer	Jaisalmer	Rawal Jaisal, 1156
Gagron	Jhalawar	Bijaldev Dod

Rajasthan's four UNESCO World Heritage properties, in order of inscription



YAAD RAKHO

Mnemonic for the six: CH-K-R-A-J-G — CHittor, Kumbhalgarh, Ranthambore, Amber, Jaisalmer, Gagron. Read it as CHAKRA-JG. Five are giri; Gagron is the odd jal durg inside a list called Hill Forts. And remember what is NOT in it — Bhainsrorgarh, in Chittorgarh district at the Chambal-Bamani confluence, called the Vellore of Rajasthan, is the tempting fourth option RPSC plants.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the Rock Art Sites of the Chambal Valley were added to India's UNESCO Tentative List on 8 February 2024. The property spans Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, and its Rajasthan clusters lie in Jhalawar, Bhilwara, Chittorgarh and Kota districts. Remember the word tentative — it is a candidate, not an inscribed site.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): India hosted the World Heritage Committee for the first time when its 46th session met in New Delhi from 21 to 31 July 2024. No Rajasthan property was inscribed at that session, so the state's count stays at four - Keoladeo 1985, Jantar Mantar 2010, the Hill Forts 2013 and the Walled City of Jaipur 2019. Of these only the Hill Forts are a serial property, and only they are a cultural landscape spread across six districts.

Chittorgarh and Kumbhalgarh — the two forts RPSC never leaves alone

Chittorgarh is the largest fort of India by area. It stands on the Mesa plateau and was founded by the Mori ruler Chitrangada. Its fame rests on three sakas — the women's mass self-immolation followed by the men riding out to die. Learn the three dates with the three attackers as a sequence; ordering questions come from here.

The three sakas of Chittorgarh



Vijay Stambh vs Kirti Stambh — the confusion RPSC exploits

Vijay Stambh	Kirti Stambh
Raised by Rana Kumbha, completed 1448	12th century, raised by the Bagherwal merchant Jija
Nine storeys, 37.19 m	Seven storeys, about 22 m
Marks victory over Mahmud Khilji of Malwa at Sarangpur, 1437	A Jain tower dedicated to Adinath
Architect Sutradhar Jaita with sons Napa, Puja and Poma	Not a Kumbha structure at all

ASKED IN RAS

Repeatedly asked — whose victory does the Vijay Stambh commemorate?

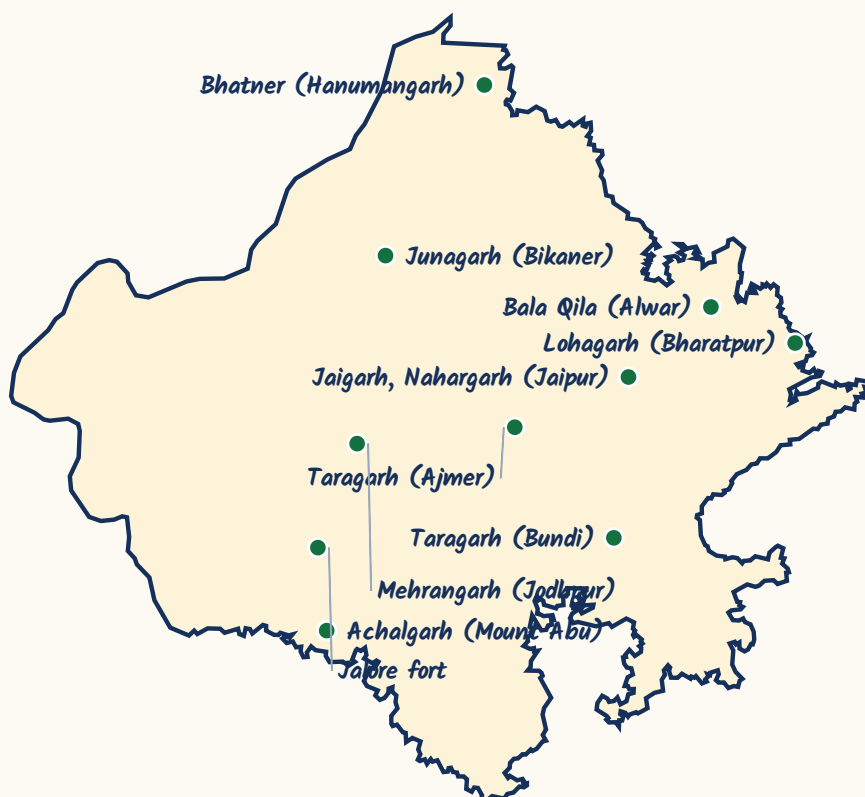
Answer: Rana Kumbha's victory over Mahmud Khilji of Malwa at Sarangpur, 1437. The tower is also the emblem of the Rajasthan Police. A second question shape asks for its architect: Sutradhar Jaita.

Kumbhalgarh is Rana Kumbha's own creation, built between 1443 and 1458 by his chief architect Mandan. Its perimeter wall runs about 36 km, which is why it is called the Great Wall of India. The innermost citadel is Katargarh. Maharana Pratap was born here. The fort fell only once, in 1578, to the Mughal general Shahbaz Khan. Keep the two architects apart: Mandan built Kumbhalgarh and wrote Prasad Mandan, Rajvallabh Mandan and Devata Murti Prakaran; Sutradhar Jaita built the Vijay Stambh.

The rest of the forts — builder, place, one identifying tag

For every remaining fort you need three things: who built it, which district it is in, and the one detail that identifies it in an option. Nothing more. Read the table across, not down.

Other major forts and their districts



Two Taragarhs — Ajmer in the centre, Bundi in Hadoti. Bhatner is the northernmost.

Fort to builder to district (set 1)

Fort	Builder / year	District & identifying tag
Jaisalmer (Sonar Quila)	Rawal Jaisal, 1156	Jaisalmer; Trikuta hill, 99 bastions, a living fort, yellow sandstone without lime mortar
Mehrangarh	Rao Jodha, 1459	Jodhpur; Chidiyatunk hill, Lohapol, Phool Mahal, Moti Mahal
Junagarh	Raja Rai Singh, 1589-94	Bikaner; supervised by Karan Chand, a plains fort not a hill fort
Amber	Raja Man Singh I, from 1592	Jaipur; Sheesh Mahal, Ganesh Pol, Diwan-i-Aam, Jagat Shiromani temple
Jaigarh	Sawai Jai Singh II, 1726	Jaipur; Chel ka Teela, the Jaivana cannon, Asia's largest cannon foundry
Nahargarh	Sawai Jai Singh II, 1734	Jaipur; first named Sudarshangarh, Madhavendra Bhawan added by Sawai Madho Singh II
Lohagarh	Maharaja Suraj Mal, 1733	Bharatpur; moat fort the British failed to take in 1805, Jawahar Burj and Fateh Burj

Fort to builder to district (set 2)

Fort	Builder / event	District & identifying tag
Bhatner	Bhupat, son of Bhati Jaisal	Hanumangarh; oldest fort of Rajasthan, on the Ghaggar, town renamed Hanumangarh in 1805
Taragarh (Garh Beetli)	Ajayaraja Chauhan	Ajmer; the Gibraltar of Rajasthan
Taragarh, Bundi	Rao Bar Singh Hada	Bundi; a separate fort of the same name
Achalgarh	Paramara fort rebuilt by Rana Kumbha, 1452	Sirohi, on Mount Abu; Achaleshwar Mahadev temple
Jalore (Sonagir / Swarnagiri / Kanchangiri)	Fell to Alauddin Khilji, 1311	Jalore; Kanhaddev's defence told in Padmanabh's Kanhadde Prabandh
Siwana	Veer Narayan Panwar	Barmer; saka of Sataldev
Shergarh	Renovated by Sher Shah Suri	Baran, on the Parwan river; another Shergarh lies in Dholpur

Fort	Builder / event	District & identifying tag
Bhainsrorgarh	Water-girt fort	Chittorgarh; Chambal-Bamani confluence, the Vellore of Rajasthan
Bala Qila	Alwar's hill fort	Alwar; also simply called Alwar Fort
Timangarh	Early medieval hill fort	Karauli

TRAP

Three planted wrong pairs to memorise as wrong. (1) Taragarh has two versions — Ajmer is Ajayaraja Chauhan's, Bundi is Rao Bar Singh Hada's. (2) Shergarh is in Baran district on the Parwan, not Jhalawar; Jhalawar's fort is Gagron. (3) Lohagarh was built by Suraj Mal — his son Jawahar Singh only raised the Jawahar Burj inside it.

- Mandalgarh, Chittorgarh and Kumbhalgarh together are called the three sentinels of Mewar.
- Jaswant Thada, built 1899 for Maharaja Jaswant Singh II, stands beside Mehrangarh.
- The Jaivana cannon was cast at Jaigarh in 1720.

Palaces — a small set, high return

Palaces are asked as palace-to-city or palace-to-builder pairs. The set is small. Learn it once and it stays.

Palace to builder to place

Palace	Builder	Place & detail
Hawa Mahal	Sawai Pratap Singh, 1799	Jaipur; architect Lal Chand Ustad, five storeys, 953 jharokhas, shaped like Krishna's crown

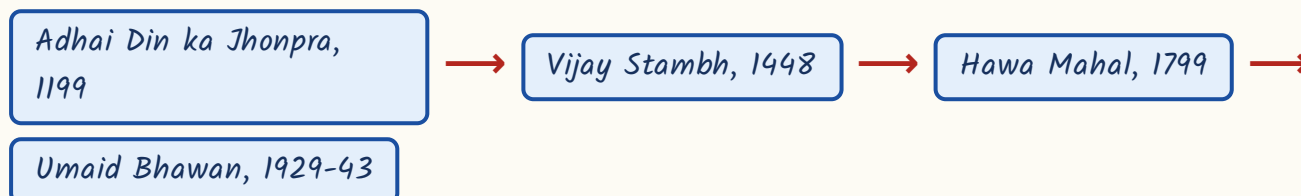
Palace	Builder	Place & detail
Umaid Bhawan (Chittar Palace)	Maharaja Umaid Singh, 1929-43	Jodhpur; architect Henry Vaughan Lanchester, Chittar sandstone, built as famine relief
Lalgarh Palace	Maharaja Ganga Singh	Bikaner; architect Sir Samuel Swinton Jacob, red Dulmera sandstone, named after his father Lall Singh
Jal Mahal	Built in the reign of Sawai Madho Singh	Jaipur; stands in the Man Sagar lake
Sukh Mahal	Bundi rulers	Bundi; on Jait Sagar lake
Padmini Mahal	-	Inside Chittorgarh fort
Jag Mandir / Jag Niwas	Mewar rulers	Udaipur; island palaces of Lake Pichola
Anup Mahal	-	Inside Junagarh, Bikaner

TRAP

Hawa Mahal is Sawai Pratap Singh's, 1799 — not Sawai Jai Singh II's. This exact swap is offered as a wrong statement. Jai Singh II founded Jaipur in 1727 and built Jaigarh and Nahargarh; Pratap Singh built Hawa Mahal.

- Samuel Swinton Jacob also designed the Albert Hall Museum at Jaipur.
- Amber remained the Kachhwaha capital until it moved to Jaipur in 1727.
- The Madhavendra Bhawan at Nahargarh has nine identical suites for the queens.

The chronological ordering question RPSC likes to build



Temples — the densest matching set in the chapter

Rajasthan's temples belong mostly to the Nagara style, with the marble Maru-Gurjara style as its western branch. Do not spend time on style theory. Spend it on temple, place, district and deity. That is what appears in List-II.

Temple sites and their districts



Nathdwara is Rajsamand; Eklingji is Udaipur. That pair is the one RPSC swaps.

Temple to place to district

Temple	Place	District & note
Dilwara Jain temples	Mount Abu	Sirohi; Maru-Gurjara marble style
Chaumukha temple of Adinath	Ranakpur	Pali; patron Dharna Shah (Porwal), architect Depak, 1,444 pillars, Kumbha's reign
Gurjara-Pratihara cluster, Sachiya Mata	Osian	Jodhpur; the Khajuraho of Rajasthan

Temple	Place	District & note
Someshwar temple, Solanki style	Kiradu	Barmer
Ambika Mata temple, 961 CE	Jagat	Udaipur; the Khajuraho of Mewar
Sas-Bahu temple, 975 CE	Nagda	Udaipur
Neelkanth Mahadev temple	Rajorgarh	Alwar; Bargujar ruler Mathandeva, Rajor inscription of 960 CE
Sun temple (Padmanabh temple), 10th c.	Jhalrapatan	Jhalawar; Jhalrapatan is the city of temple bells
Harshnath Shiva temple	Harshnath	Sikar
Ghateshwar Mahadev temple	Baroli	Chittorgarh
Mahanaleshwar Shiva complex	Menal	Chittorgarh; on the Chambal-side plateau near Begun

Dilwara — learn the four names as one block

The Dilwara temples

Temple	Patron / year	Dedicated to
Vimal Vasahi	Vimal Shah, 1031	Adinath
Luna Vasahi	Vastupal and Tejpal, 1230	Neminath
Pittalhar	Bhima Shah	Adinath (large brass image)
Khartar Vasahi	-	Parshvanath

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — the Neelkanth Mahadev temple at Rajorgarh, referred to in the Rajor inscription of 960 CE, was built by whom? Answer: Mathandeva of the Bargujar (Badgujar) line, in present-day Alwar district.

TRAP

The Ambika Mata temple at Jagat is in UDAIPUR district, not Rajsamand. Nathdwara and Kumbhalgarh are Rajsamand; Jagat and Nagda are Udaipur. Jagat-Rajsamand has been used as the wrong pair.

- Sun temples of Rajasthan: Jhalrapatan (Jhalawar), Osian, Varman (Sirohi), Surya Narayan at Ranakpur.
- Achaleshwar Mahadev at Achalgarh worships a toe-impression of Shiva instead of a linga.
- Eklingji (Udaipur), Nathdwara (Rajsamand), the Brahma temple at Pushkar and Govind Dev Ji (Jaipur) are the major living shrines.

Ajmer's Indo-Islamic monuments

A small cluster, but it is asked because it is the earliest Indo-Islamic building in Rajasthan and because it sits on top of a Hindu institution. Get the builder and the date right.

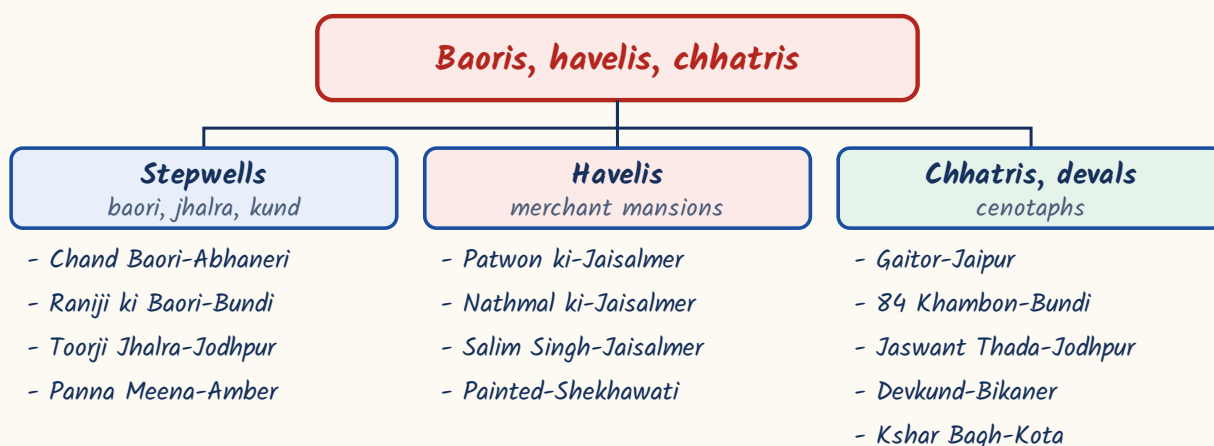
- Adhai Din ka Jhonpra, Ajmer — raised by Qutbuddin Aibak in 1199.
- It stands on the site of a Sanskrit college founded by the Chauhan ruler Vigraharaja IV.
- The arched screen in front was added later by Iltutmish.
- The Dargah of Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti at Ajmer is the other great monument of the town.
- Tarkin ka Darwaza at Nagaur belongs to the same early tradition.

Use 1199 as your date anchor. In almost every RPSC ordering question on Rajasthan architecture, Adhai Din ka Jhonpra is the oldest item on the list and therefore goes first.

Stepwells, havelis and chhatris

Water architecture and memorial architecture close the chapter. Both are pure place-matching. Only four stepwell names ever appear in the options — Chand at Dausa, Rani at Bundi, Toorji at Jodhpur, Panna Meena at Amber. C-R-T-P.

Water and memorial architecture



Stepwell to place

Stepwell	Place / district	Detail
Chand Baori	Abhaneri, Dausa	Nikumbha ruler Chanda, c. 8th-9th century; about 3,500 steps, 13 storeys; adjoins the Harshat Mata temple
Raniji ki Baori	Bundi	Built 1699 by Rani Nathavati
Toorji ka Jhalra	Jodhpur	-
Panna Meena ka Kund	Amber, Jaipur	-

Havelis

- Patwon ki Haveli, Jaisalmer — commissioned by Guman Chand Patwa in 1805; a cluster of five, the largest haveli of Rajasthan.
- Nathmal ki Haveli and Salim Singh ki Haveli are also at Jaisalmer; Salim Singh's has a peacock-shaped upper storey.
- The painted havelis of Shekhawati are concentrated at Nawalgarh, Mandawa and Fatehpur.

Chhatris and devals

- Gaitor, Jaipur — cenotaphs of the Kachhwaha rulers from Sawai Jai Singh II onward; the queens' cenotaphs stand at Maharani ki Chhatri.
- Chaurasi Khambon ki Chhatri, Devpura, Bundi — eighty-four pillars, raised by Rao Anirudh Singh.
- Jaswant Thada, Jodhpur (1899); Devkund, Bikaner; Kshar Bagh, Kota.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 as a match set — Gagron / Jhalawar, Bhatner / Hanumangarh, Kumbhalgarh / Rajsamand, Taragarh / Ajmer. Fort-to-district is the single most reliable question shape in this chapter, so revise the two builder tables above before every mock.

REVISION RECAP

1. Fort types: giri hill, jal water, dhanva desert, van forest, eran ravine, parikh moat, sahay allies, sainya army.
2. Gagron = jal durg, Kali Sindh + Ahu, Jhalawar, Bijaldev Dod, no laid foundation, sakas 1423 and 1444.
3. Ranthambore = giri durg, never jal. Lohagarh = parikh durg.
4. Six UNESCO Hill Forts, 2013: Chittorgarh, Kumbhalgarh, Ranthambore, Amber, Jaisalmer, Gagron. Not Bhainsrorgarh.
5. Rajasthan's four World Heritage sites: Keoladeo 1985, Jantar Mantar 2010, Hill Forts 2013, Walled City Jaipur 2019.

6. Chittorgarh: largest fort of India by area, Mesa plateau, founder Chitrangada Mori, sakas 1303, 1535, 1568.
7. Vijay Stambh = Kumbha, 1448, nine storeys, 37.19 m, architect Sutradhar Jaita, victory at Sarangpur 1437. Kirti Stambh = Jija, Adinath, seven storeys, 12th century.
8. Kumbhalgarh = Kumbha with architect Mandan, 36-km wall, Katargarh citadel, Pratap's birthplace, Rajsamand.
9. Mehrangarh Rao Jodha 1459; Junagarh Rai Singh 1589-94; Amber Man Singh I 1592; Jaigarh 1726 and Nahargarh 1734 both Sawai Jai Singh II.
10. Bhatner = oldest fort, on the Ghaggar, Hanumangarh. Taragarh Ajmer = Garh Beetli, Ajayaraja Chauhan, Gibraltar of Rajasthan.
11. Hawa Mahal 1799 Sawai Pratap Singh, architect Lal Chand Ustad, 953 jharokhas. Umaid Bhawan by Lanchester as famine relief. Lalgarh by Ganga Singh, architect Swinton Jacob.
12. Ranakpur = Chaumukha Adinath, Pali, patron Dharna Shah, architect Depak, 1,444 pillars.
13. Dilwara: Vimal Vasahi 1031 Adinath, Luna Vasahi 1230 Neminath, Pittalhar Bhima Shah, Khartar Vasahi Parshvanath.
14. Osian = Khajuraho of Rajasthan (Jodhpur); Jagat = Khajuraho of Mewar (Udaipur, 961 CE).
15. Rajorgarh Neelkanth Mahadev by Mathandeva, Rajor inscription 960 CE, Alwar.
16. Adhai Din ka Jhonpra 1199, Qutbuddin Aibak, on Vighraharaja IV's Sanskrit college; screen added by Iltutmish.
17. Chand Baori at Abhaneri in Dausa, about 3,500 steps; Raniji ki Baori at Bundi, 1699, Rani Nathavati.
18. Patwon ki Haveli, Jaisalmer, 1805, Guman Chand Patwa, largest in Rajasthan; Chaurasi Khambon ki Chhatra at Bundi.